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English 102

10 Sep 2023

Vertical Thought: How to Apply Rock Climbing to Everyday Life

As someone who has played soccer since he was four, switching to rock climbing my senior year surprised me with how different it felt to climb. I soon began to realize that climbing challenges its followers to master tension and friction, not holding onto rocks really hard. Sports such as soccer began with the bloodthirsty Romans, while climbing was derived from a band of fools who wanted to reach the top of Yosemite. Climbing teaches, heals, and applies to almost every aspect of our lives. Rock climbing is not the traditional sport built on the foundation of competition but a passion powered by curiosity. “Instead of the god of security, we bow to the greater god of freedom, the freedom to take risks and master danger in order to be intensely alive - Royal Robbins.” (“Royal” par. 2).

I was introduced to rock climbing from a friend my senior year of high school. The first time was at the closest climbing gym to me: Inner Peaks, in Charlotte, NC. Stressed from the social and performance standards of soccer, I took a year away from school soccer senior year. This decision resulted in a very peaceful senior year, causing me to grow restless. I decided to try rock climbing with my friend, Hank, who occasionally went to Inner Peaks with his girlfriend. Much of my senior year consisted of school in the mornings and climbing in the evenings. Typically just Hank and I would go climbing with the occasional special guest, and I grew even closer to myself and Hank. Certain muscles also grew, such as my forearms, back, and shoulders. Climbing paved the way for a mountain of social, mental, and physical benefits in my life.

I swiftly fell in love with the feeling of climbing: the feeling of accomplishment from topping a climb that had bested me multiple times, the feeling of intensity from working multiple muscle groups during a complex move, and the feeling of freedom from the self-autonomous nature of climbing. The first time I ever climbed, there was a V3 boulder, a difficulty of climb, that I was so close to getting, but after countless attempts I had peaked my first challenge, and I was hooked. The feeling of accomplishment from completing my first project, or repeated climb, never left my mind, and I often would recognize the exact feeling in my friends who I introduced climbing to. We left a bit to be desired on my first trip to Inner peaks because my forearms refused to suspend my body any longer. The strain from completing that villainous V3 greatly exceeded my expectations of intensity. Muscles that previously never existed in my world were now crucial in completing complex climbs. I noticed the workout from climbing quickly grew my forearms, back, and shoulders. Lastly, I noticed the freedom of climbing how I wanted to during my first experience. Many climbs in the gym and on the cliff face are open to interpretation. For example, Hank, who is six feet two inches tall, climbs with a simplistic style, while I take advantage of my legs much more often than him to reach higher holds. The route that a climber takes up the wall is known as a beta in the climbing community. I formulated my own beta for each climb, which fed into my creative hunger. The feeling of being able to climb on my own hours instead of routine soccer practices was liberating; this feeling, along with the need to chalk up a personalized beta, allowed me to understand the lesser-known, creative side of climbing. The creative freedom fed into a meditative sense of climbing. A major reason I enjoyed climbing is because of how solitary the wall feels when climbing. There is a realization that I am the only one on the wall, and my thoughts begin to wander, much like the inherent

nature of climbing. The curiosity of testing a different beta, along with my mind being restricted to speak with itself, gave me a few hours to reflect on my days.

Climbing applies to everyday life by teaching various mental and physical skills. Royal Robbins, the first climber to ascend Half-Dome, climbed the cliff face for five days (Gates par. 2). Alex Honnald, first man to free solo El Capitan, prepared for over two years (Simpkins par. 5), and Warren Harding, first man to climb El Capitan, climbed for forty seven days ("Warren" par. 1). Climbing requires a large amount of preparation, problem solving, and critical thinking. For example, climbing models scientific theory. The scientific theory has six main steps. Step one: ask a question - Can I climb this? Step two: Do background research - Ask other climbers for betas. Step three: Make a hypothesis - make a beta, or route, for a climb. Step four: Test with an experiment - climb the beta. Step five: Analyze data - I climbed it, or I failed it, and why. Step six: Communicate your results - tell others your beta.The process of climbing a problem mimics scientific theory deeper than that, however. Thinking about an experiment in science, there is an independent variable, the climber, a dependent variable, the success of the climb, and there are constants, the wall, or climb. Climbing can also build self awareness, and can reveal a new perspective of oneself. Phadke argues in "What Rock Climbing Taught Me About Engineering," that watching other climbers as well as failing his own climbs has taught him to critique himself more often, and become more "self-critical." (flatiron, par. 7)

While aiding climbers in growing mentally, climbing inherently aids physical growth in climbers as well. Climbing predominantly builds back, shoulders, and forearms, but climbing is actually a sneaky full-body workout(McManus par. 10). Climbing works core, lower-body, and cardiovascular muscles when using good climbing technique (McManus par. 11). The ability to

hold one's body in a position using obscure muscles is a core factor of climbing. For example a heel hook, works the calf and hamstring, or by mantling, works the tricep and pectoral muscles.

Climbing acts as a medium for healing and therapy as well. The low maintenance activity, as well as the physical workout can relieve stress, and help mentally heal climbers. On the other hand, the complex actions of climbing can help physically heal injuries for certain climbers. An experiment done in Germany consisting of 198 random participants, proved that bouldering psychotherapy, a form of therapy through the medium of bouldering, was more effective in reducing depression levels than an exercise programme or cognitive behavioral therapy (Karg et al. pars. 1-2). The bouldering psychotherapy, on average, reduced depression in participants by a severity level(Karg et al. par. 1). This is resulted from the stress relieving properties of exercise, as well as the improved body image. However, the mental aspects of climbing, such as the satisfaction of solving a climb, and the social atmosphere of a climbing gym could explain the increase in participants' ability to cope with depression and social skills.

Climbing can physically heal certain areas of the body, such as back pain, shoulder pain, shoulder mobility, calcaneal fractures, multiple sclerosis, and many disorders (Liu et al. par. 4). This is proven through a research experiment that whittled six hundred and seventeen articles down to seventy nine regarding therapeutic climbing (Liu et al. par. 2). The thought behind the process of healing is that climbing requires complex movements such as climbing diagonally, working obscure muscles, and the alteration between dynamic and static movements (Liu et al. par. 5). These unorthodox techniques can work entire systems of muscles in order to heal damaged structures in the body (Liu et al. par. 5).

Climbing can be applied to everyday life mentally, physically, to heal, and to teach. In a sense, humans use many core values of climbing in everyday life without realizing it. John

Bachar, legendary free solo climber, put it best, “Everybody free-solos. When you walk to the store, you're free-soloing. It's just a matter of the difficulty of the route.” (“John” par. 3).

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